

1.5 Unit 1, Option C: The British Empire: Colonisation and Decolonisation

Focus

This option concentrates on the theme of colonisation and decolonisation from the perspective of Britain and selected colonies, with further emphasis on how the British Empire developed and expanded and how ideas about the value and benefits of the Empire developed and were challenged. Whichever combinations are chosen, this option enables students to understand the importance of both economic and cultural factors and of identity and rights, both in the expansion of and in challenges to imperial expansion and consolidation.

Clarification of content for each topic can be found in *Appendix 1*.

Students entered for Option C are required to study TWO of the topics from C1-C7.

C1 The Origins of the British Empire, c1680-1763

- The link between commerce and the development of empire: the roles of the East India, Royal Africa and South Sea companies.
- The role of Government in protecting trade and facilitating imperial expansion and the impact of the Navigation Acts.
- The role of war in imperial expansion: wars against Louis XIV; Jenkins' Ear; the Austrian Succession; Seven Years War.

C2 Relations with the American Colonies and the War of Independence, c1740-89

- Relations between the American colonies and the Mother Country, 1740-63: commerce, governance and Anglo-French rivalry.
- British policies towards the colonies and the growth of opposition, 1763-75.
- The American Revolution: causes, course and reasons for colonies' success in achieving independence.
- The impact of independence on Britain and America, 1783-89.

C3 The Slave Trade, Slavery and the Anti-slavery Campaigns, c1760-1833

- Reasons for, and growing extent of, British involvement in the slave trade.
- The structure and operation of slavery in British colonies.
- The anti-slavery campaigns: the role of the Evangelical movement; the roles of Thomas Clarkson and William Wilberforce; the nature of support for abolition.
- Nature and extent of, and reasons for, opposition and resistance to the anti-slave trade and anti-slavery movements and reasons why this opposition failed; abolition of the slave trade in 1807 and abolition of slavery in the Empire in 1833.

C4 Commerce and Conquest: India, c1760-c1835

- The importance of the East India Company in the development of India from 1760: the company's growing difficulties; the East India Company Act of 1773; the India Bills of 1783-84; the Charter Acts of 1813 and 1833 and their significance.
- The impact and significance of Anglo-French rivalry in India from 1760 and of the outcome of the Seven Years War for British rule in India.
- Relations between the British and the Indian princes and implications for the expansion of British rule; relations with the Marathas; the Mysore Wars.
- Cornwallis, Wellesley and Hastings as Governor Generals of India; impact of missionary activity and attack on Indian customs in the 1820s and early 1830s.

C5 Commerce and Imperial Expansion, c1815-70

- The importance of the Napoleonic wars for the expansion of the British Empire: growing worldwide influence; colonial acquisitions at the end of the wars and their significance.
- The relationship between the Empire and British industrialisation: the role of the Empire in supplying raw materials for the Mother Country and as a recipient of British-manufactured goods.
- The concept of 'formal' and 'informal' empire; the importance of the navy in securing an imperial presence.
- The concept of the 'Pax Britannica' and the significance of Christianity in development of imperial ideas and attitudes.

C6 Britain and the Scramble for Africa, c1875-1914

- Britain's growing interests in North Africa: acquisition of Suez canal shares and its significance; the concept of an 'informal' empire.
- Nature and extent of imperial acquisitions in Africa in this period.
- Conflict in Southern Africa: reasons for, and consequences of, the two Boer Wars.
- The development of imperial attitudes: British perceptions of the benefits of the Empire for indigenous peoples; advantages and disadvantages of the Empire for the British in this period.

C7 Retreat from Empire: Decolonisation in Africa, c1957-81

- Reasons why the British Empire was difficult to sustain: costs of maintenance; impact of the Second World War; Britain's declining influence in world affairs.
- Reasons for, and nature of, independence movements in Africa in the 1950s and early 1960s: reasons why decolonisation in British colonies in Africa came about so quickly in the 1950s and 1960s.
- Extent to which decolonisation was accompanied by an orderly transition or by violence.
- Attempts at decolonisation in southern Africa: the cases of South Africa and Southern Rhodesia (Zimbabwe), 1960-81.